Bangladesh are Muslims. And the constitution they created was a secular one with socialist inclinations. I mean, naturally, any country that is essentially very poor would think in those terms; they would like to have a much more egalitarian society."

"I think it's worked out, because the film appears to be a huge success in Bangladesh and now in various places outside of Bangladesh where the film has been released. Not so much in India, strangely enough, but in western Europe, Britain and Canada, the film is running extremely well, which I didn't particularly expect would happen. The people who constitute this audience worldwide are largely obviously Bangladeshi, because they have a great sense of affinity for the man and for what he's done for them, for their own dignity and self-respect."

Now that *Mujib* is out in the world, Benegal's mind is already busy with plans. "I don't necessarily discuss the subjects I want to make," he says, but does reveal that he has a couple of projects in mind. Much depends on whether his health will hold up. He turned 89 shortly after this interview, which had to fit into a day when he did not have to go for his dialysis appointments. His hands have a slight tremor, he uses a hearing aid and a walking stick. But the brightness of his eyes makes one forget all that. "I can't do something that takes a lot of energy out of me. A big subject would be very difficult to do now; *Mujib* was almost an epic. I would have to do something on a slightly smaller scale. All I can say is that it would be about concepts of development." ■

Peter Griffin

FATHERS AND SONS

Kunal Sen paints an intimate portrait of his father, film director Mrinal Sen, in *Bondhu*

Mrinal Sen's birth centenary inspired a series of programmes across Indian film festivals last year and films from Bengali directors Anjan Dutt, Srijit Mukherji and Kaushik Ganguly. Amidst the fanfare has arrived the very intimate *Bondhu*, a memoir from his son Kunal Sen.

Kunal has cut through the legacy of his father as a serious Leftist intellectual who rivalled Satyajit Ray and Ritwik Ghatak to arrive at a portrait of a humorous, self-absorbed but kind, middle-class man. The title *Bondhu*, meaning friend in Bengali, is what Kunal would call his father. He writes in the book, "...playing with me one day, he might have said that the two of us were friends, and somehow that got stuck in my mind. Whatever the reason, that is the only name I remember calling him."

Based in Chicago, Kunal, 68, is a computer scientist and technologist. He had never been a writer. When Kunal began writing *Bondhu*, he knew what to avoid. "I did not want to write a chronological biography, as others have done an excellent job," says Kunal. "I also did not want to talk about the aesthetics of his films since no one wants to hear the praise from a close relative."



BONDHU
My Father, My Friend
By Kunal Sen
SEAGULL BOOKS
₹599; 198 pages



DOCUMENTING A TIME
Sen on the set of *Ek Din Pratidin*

Instead, he wove each chapter around a separate theme, such as Mrinal Sen's early friends in Kolkata; his wife and Kunal's mother, Gita Sen, who died in 2017; his filmmaking process; and his final years. Then Kunal clubbed the chapters under three sections: 'Bondhu', 'Filmmaker' and 'Father'.

Bondhu flows in an episodic, anecdotal manner that is steadfastly unsentimental. "My father was also allergic to sentimentalism," explains Kunal. "It is also hard to gain the trust of the reader when one writes about a close relative. One way to win that trust back is by distancing oneself a little. Apart from that, perhaps my scientific training also compels me to be as objective as I can manage."

Nonetheless, *Bondhu* is bookended by two poignant moments: Sen playing hide-and-seek with a four-year-old Kunal on a wintry morning in the huge grounds of Kolkata Maidan, and Kunal musing about the "few unshareable things" about his parents "that are directly connected to my senses and my mind", such as how they smelled.

Interestingly, Kunal is unsure about whether Sen's films, many of which circle Marxist themes, will be relevant to present generations. "The value of an artist depends largely on the prevailing social mindscape of the future, and that is very hard to predict," he writes.

Kunal admits that his assessment may have been wrong. A few days before the interview, Kunal was present during a screening of Sen's *Padatik* (1973), based on a Naxal's self-doubts in the '70s Kolkata, where he was surprised to see young people reacting positively. "A thinking audience can still find relevant connections," he says. "My father's films rarely reached a broad audience, but perhaps there will always be a small audience everywhere that would be able to make that connection." ■

Devarsi Ghosh